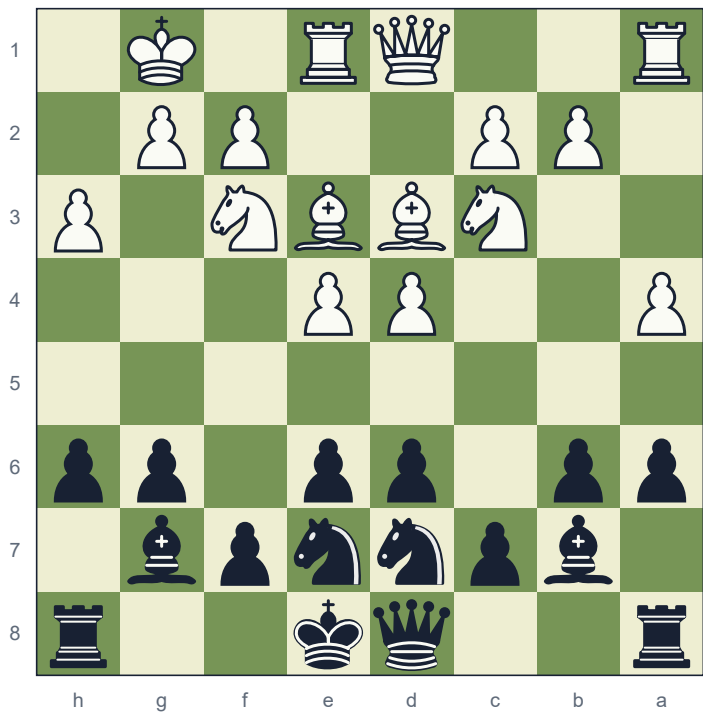


Hippopotamus as Black

A complete practical curriculum from the ground up

The Hippo is a restrained double fianchetto: often ...b6, ...Bb7, ...g6, ...Bg7, ...d6, ...e6, ...Nd7 and ...Ne7, with ...a6 and ...h6 only when useful. Black concedes space and frequently an objective edge. Timely departures from the full formation are essential.



The reference position - White to move

YOUR PERSPECTIVE

Black is at the bottom of every diagram. Coordinates remain explicit and all pieces stay upright.

WHAT YOU WILL LEARN

24 opening branches, six middlegame laboratories, 48 exercises with explained answers, and a 12-week practice plan. Each subject also appears in one combined volume.

START HERE

Read this booklet first. Then learn one line from each family in Booklet 01. Use 02 for plans, 03 for practice positions, 04 for retrieval and 05 for study schedules and reference.

How to use this course

YOUR FIRST PASS

Use a real or digital board. Read the foundations, then learn only the first line of each opening family. Play slow practice games before trying to remember every variation. A useful opening lesson ends with a decision you can explain, not a string of moves you can recite.

YOUR SECOND PASS

Return to the branch your opponent actually played. Replay it from move one and stop before each move by your side. Name the threat, two plausible replies and the reason for your choice. Check the printed continuation only after committing to an answer.

YOUR THIRD PASS

Use the middlegame laboratories and exercise book. These are original illustrative positions and engine-assisted continuations, not attributed master games. Switch colors in training so you experience the opponent's space, defensive resources and attacking chances.

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This is a broad practical curriculum from basic rules to common opening decisions, middlegames and typical transitions. Chess has too many legal branches for a finite course to exhaust. The course teaches a decision process for unfamiliar replies and marks alternatives, warnings and entry-route boundaries explicitly.

The board and the object of the game

COORDINATES

Files are a through h from White's left to right. Ranks are 1 through 8 from White's side toward Black. A square such as e4 has one file letter and one rank number. White has a light square at the near right corner, h1. Black-oriented diagrams reverse the coordinate display, not the movement rules.

URNS AND CHECK

White moves first; the players alternate one move each. A move may not leave your own king attacked. Check means that the king is attacked; answer by moving the king, capturing the attacker or blocking a line attack when possible. A knight check cannot be blocked.

CHECKMATE AND STALEMATE

Checkmate means the player to move is in check and has no legal reply. Stalemate means the player has no legal move but is not in check; it is a draw. Before announcing mate, examine every king move, capture and possible block. Kings are never actually captured.

MATERIAL IS A GUIDE

For beginner decisions, a pawn is roughly 1, a knight or bishop 3, a rook 5 and a queen 9. These are rough comparisons, not a scoring rule. A king has no exchange value. Activity, safety, passed pawns and immediate tactics can outweigh a small material difference.

How the pieces move

ROOK AND BISHOP

A rook moves along a rank or file. A bishop moves diagonally and stays on its starting square color. Neither can jump over any piece. A sliding piece controls only as far as the first occupied square on each ray; do not count an attack through your own pawn.

QUEEN AND KNIGHT

A queen combines rook and bishop movement. A knight moves two squares in one direction and one at right angles, changing square color. The knight may jump over pieces. A knight on f3 can move to d2, d4, e1, e5, g1, g5, h2 or h4 if the destination and king-safety rules allow.

KING

A king moves one square in any direction and cannot enter an attacked square. The kings cannot stand next to each other. A pinned enemy piece can still restrict the king's legal squares; the rules about attacked squares are more subtle than whether that enemy piece could legally move away from its own king.

PAWN

White pawns move toward higher rank numbers; Black pawns toward lower. A pawn moves one square straight ahead into an empty square, or two from its starting rank if both squares are empty. It captures one square diagonally forward. It cannot move backward or capture straight ahead.

Castling, promotion and en passant

CASTLING

Castling moves the king two squares toward a rook and places that rook on the square the king crossed. The king and that rook must never have moved, the intervening squares must be empty, and the king must not be in check or cross or land on an attacked square. A rook being attacked does not by itself prevent castling.

RIGHTS DO NOT RETURN

If a king or rook moves out and back, the relevant castling right is still lost. A king moved to f1 in the King's Gambit must coordinate its rooks another way. In queenless positions the loss of castling may be less serious, but the legal right remains lost.

PROMOTION

A pawn reaching the last rank must promote to a queen, rook, bishop or knight of its color. It need not choose a previously captured piece. A second queen is legal. Underpromotion can avoid stalemate or create a knight fork, so inspect the exact position before always choosing a queen.

EN PASSANT

Immediately after an opposing pawn advances two squares from its starting rank and lands beside your pawn on your fifth rank, you may capture it as though it had advanced one square. The opportunity lasts only for your next move. The capture is illegal if removing those pawns exposes your own king to check.

Reading moves and navigating branches

ALGEBRAIC NOTATION

K means king, Q queen, R rook, B bishop and N knight. Pawns have no piece letter: e4 is a pawn move. Bc4 means a bishop moves to c4. Nxe5 captures on e5. exd5 is an e-file pawn capturing on d5. A plus sign is check; # is checkmate; O-O is kingside castling and O-O-O queenside castling.

WHICH PIECE MOVED

If two identical pieces can legally reach the same square, notation distinguishes them: Nbd2 means the knight from the b-file; R1e2 means the rook from rank 1. The board, not the notation alone, determines which capture or check is legal. Promotion is written e8=Q, with + or # when appropriate.

MOVE NUMBERS

1.e4 e5 is White's first move and Black's first reply. A line beginning 7...Nf6 starts with Black's seventh move. All main opening lines in this course begin at the initial position; laboratory continuations display their starting diagram and exact move number.

ONE LINE IS NOT FORCED

An example to move ten is one route through the position. It is not a claim that every reply is compulsory. The authored anchor and its illustrative continuation are distinguished. Each line has an ID that also appears in the PGN files and exercises.

Your thinking routine on every move

1. INSPECT THE LAST MOVE

Ask what the opponent's move changed. Did it attack a piece, unmask a bishop, release a rook file, threaten mate or leave something undefended? A remembered opening move is only a candidate until it survives this inspection.

2. EXAMINE FORCING MOVES

Check all checks, serious captures and direct threats for both sides. Calculate the opponent's best reply, not the reply you hope for. Stop the line at a position you can assess: material, king safety and the resulting pawn structure.

3. GENERATE CANDIDATES

Usually compare two or three useful moves: one forcing move, one developing or improving move, and one central response if relevant. In a cramped position ask which exchange or pawn break creates room. In an attacking position ask whether the center can open against your king.

4. BLUNDER CHECK

Before moving, visualize the new position. Is your queen or another piece loose? Have you removed a defender or opened a diagonal to your king? Can the opponent answer with a check, fork or intermediate capture? A ten-second check often saves more points than memorizing another opening branch.

Center, development and time

OCCUPY AND INFLUENCE

Pawns on d4 and e4 occupy central space; bishops and knights can influence those squares from a distance. A restrained setup needs a plan to challenge the opponent's center. Space becomes useful when it gives your pieces safe squares and restricts the opponent.

DEVELOPMENT

Bring knights and bishops into useful play, protect the king and connect the rooks. Avoid moving the same piece repeatedly without a concrete gain. An exception must be explained: a queen retreat in the Scandinavian or a knight escape in the King's Gambit can be compulsory.

A TEMPO

A tempo is one move of useful time. Attacking a queen while developing often gains time, but a check that helps the opponent develop can fail to do so. Count actual useful moves and threats instead of assuming every attack is a gain.

OPENING THE CENTER

If your king is safer and your pieces are ready, opening files can exploit a development lead. If your king is exposed, central exchanges may be dangerous. A closed center often allows maneuvering or a wing attack, but first verify that the opponent cannot open it with a pawn break.

Pawn structures and planning vocabulary

BREAK AND TENSION

A pawn break challenges an enemy pawn structure: c4 against d5 or ...c5 against d4. Tension exists when pawns can capture each other but neither side has committed. Before exchanging, ask which pieces become active, which file opens and which pawn becomes weak.

CHAIN AND BASE

A pawn chain is a diagonal line of mutually supporting pawns. In a white d4-e5 chain, d4 is the base and e5 the head. An attack on either end may work, but the calculation differs: ...c5 usually challenges d4, while ...f6 challenges e5.

WEAK SQUARES AND OUTPOSTS

A square is a useful outpost when a piece can occupy it securely and create meaningful pressure, often because enemy pawns cannot chase it. An outpost with no targets may be less valuable than a flexible central piece. Check whether exchanges eliminate its support.

FILES, DIAGONALS AND LEVERS

A file without pawns is open; one with no pawn of your color is half-open for you. A fianchetto bishop can be excellent on an open diagonal and restricted behind blocked pawns. A lever changes that reality. Name the pawn move that makes your plan possible.

Playing, recording and analyzing a game

CHOOSE A USEFUL TIME CONTROL

For course practice use at least 15 minutes with an increment, or a longer control if available. Blitz is useful for pattern recognition after the basic decisions are learned. It is a poor substitute for calculating an unfamiliar sharp opening carefully.

ANALYZE YOURSELF FIRST

After the game, mark the first unfamiliar position and write your candidates without an engine. Identify the first important mistake, not only the final blunder. Separate opening memory, tactical calculation, strategic judgment and time-management errors.

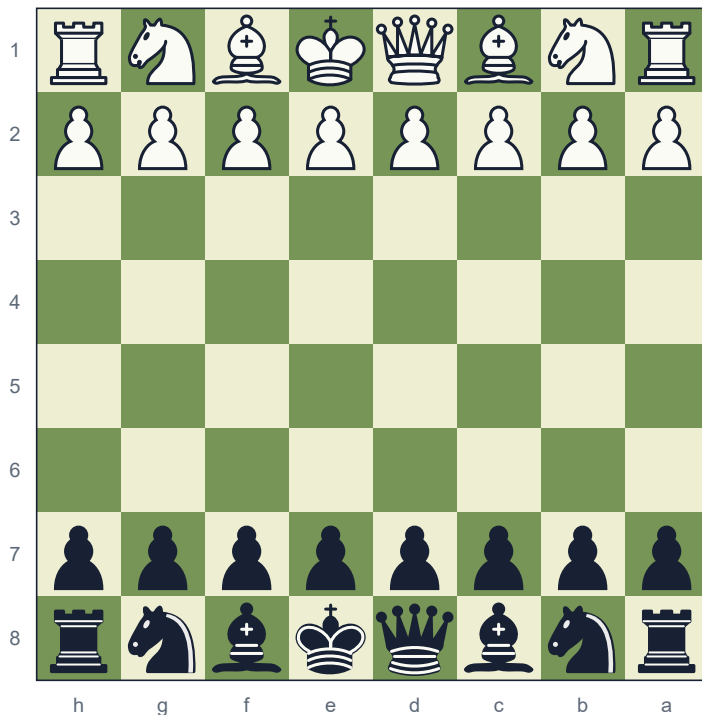
THEN USE THE TOOLS

Compare the game with the matching line ID. Use an engine to test forcing variations and examine a stronger defensive reply. An engine number is evidence from a finite search, not a verbal explanation. Write one sentence that tells you what to do differently next time.

BUILD A SMALL ERROR NOTEBOOK

Keep the position, your move, a better candidate, the opponent's key reply and one lesson. Revisit it after one day, three days, a week and a month. Add the position to your repertoire only when you can explain it without the answer visible.

Read the diagram before the moves



White to move

A RELIABLE FIRST SCAN

Find both kings, name the side to move and locate all pawns in the center. Then inspect checks, captures and direct threats.

ORIENTATION

Your course side is at the bottom. On a Black-oriented board, files read h to a along the bottom; pawns still move according to their color and rank numbers.

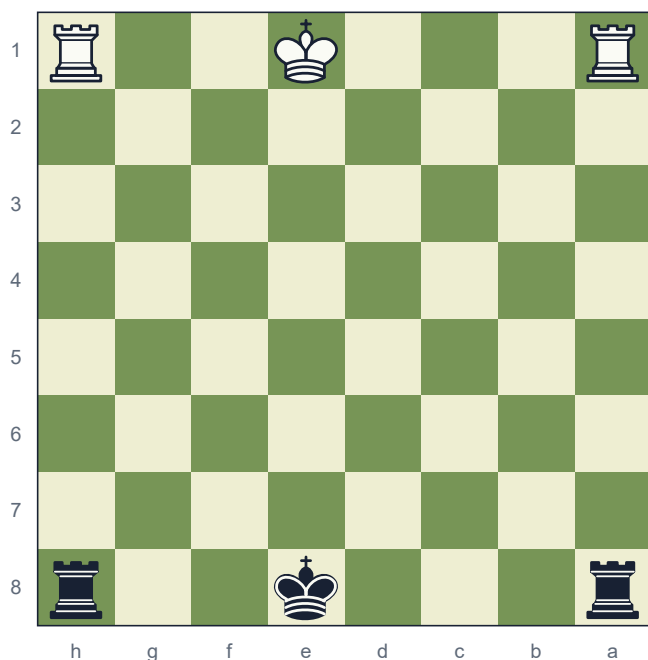
PRACTICE WITHOUT MOVING

Find e4, d5, f7 and b2. Name the piece that begins on each of b1, c1, f8 and g8. From the initial position, count White's legal pawn moves and knight moves: 16 pawn moves and 4 knight moves.

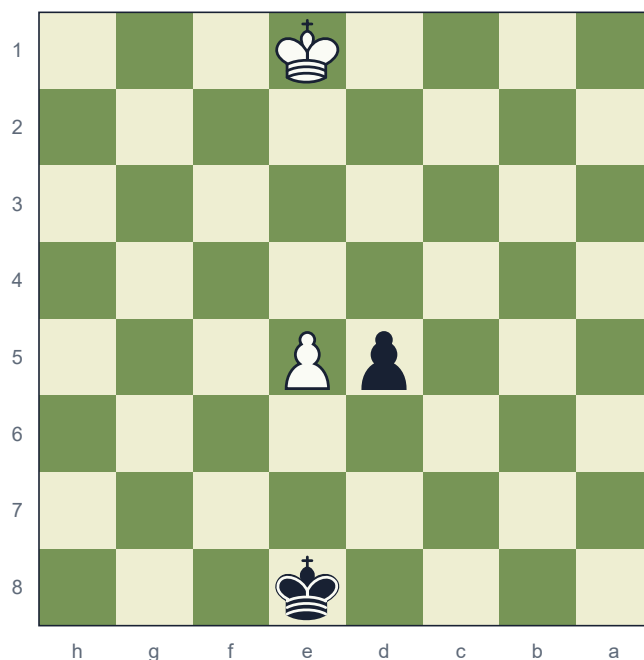
ANSWER THE REAL POSITION

A board caption always states whose move it is and whether the king is in check. You may not ignore check to finish development. In the initial position, bishops and rooks are blocked by friendly pieces.

Castling and en passant on a board



White to move - castling geometry



White to move - en passant available

LEFT: CASTLING GEOMETRY

With the rights recorded in this teaching position, White may castle O-O or O-O-O. The king crosses f1 or d1 and lands on g1 or c1; the rook lands on f1 or d1. Empty squares alone are not enough in a real game: check previous king/rook moves and attacked king squares.

RIGHT: IMMEDIATE EN PASSANT

Black has just played ...d7-d5. White can play exd6 en passant: the white pawn lands on d6 and the black pawn is removed from d5. If White plays another move, the special capture is no longer available.

TRAINING QUESTION

Why can a knight jump over a piece but a bishop cannot? Why can a rook be attacked during legal castling while the king cannot cross an attacked square? Explain the movement rule before using it in an opening.

Your first moves, explained

1... G6

Prepares a fianchetto and changes the long diagonal. Check the bishop and corner rook before assuming the next developing move is safe.

2... BG7

Completes the kingside fianchetto. Before placing the bishop, check that an opposing bishop cannot capture it along an open diagonal.

3... D6

Supports a restrained central formation and opens one bishop diagonal while possibly blocking another. Plan the later pawn break.

4... A6

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

5... B6

Prepares a fianchetto and changes the long diagonal. Check the bishop and corner rook before assuming the next developing move is safe.

BEFORE YOU MEMORIZE

The reference route is one example. Reconstruct it, then change one opposing move and explain why the next automatic setup move might need to change.

Your first moves, explained / continued

6... BB7

Completes the queenside fianchetto and points toward e4. Count the diagonal's blockers before claiming immediate pressure.

7... E6

Supports a restrained central formation and opens one bishop diagonal while possibly blocking another. Plan the later pawn break.

8... ND7

Develops a knight toward central supporting squares. Keep a useful onward route so the compact setup does not become overcrowded.

9... H6

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

10... NE7

Develops the king knight while keeping the f-pawn flexible. It may support a central break or move toward g6 or c6 if safe.

BEFORE YOU MEMORIZE

The reference route is one example. Reconstruct it, then change one opposing move and explain why the next automatic setup move might need to change.

Repertoire map / 1

BUILDING THE FORMATION AGAINST A CLASSICAL CENTER

Start with HB-01. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

HB-01 The full formation as a study position

The formation is a starting point for decisions.

HB-02 White chooses Be2

Quiet opponents can win by restricting every break.

HB-03 White develops Be3 and Qd2

Identify the opponent's king choice before fixing yours.

HB-04 White fianchettoes the king bishop

Opening a diagonal can activate both bishops.

HB-05 White keeps the c-pawn on c2

Watch the next central expansion, not only the current one.

HB-06 An early queen exchange option

Once the center opens, leave the formation mindset.

Repertoire map / 2

LARGE CENTERS AND EARLY PAWN ATTACKS

Start with HB-07. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

HB-07 The three-pawn center

More opposing space demands earlier central action.

HB-08 The four-pawn center

Against four pawns, finish development and challenge them.

HB-09 The Austrian-style f4 center

Counterplay must arrive before the center breaks open.

HB-10 An immediate h-pawn attack

Stopping one lever creates a new contact to monitor.

HB-11 White plays g4 early

Counter a wing attack through the center when it is safe.

HB-12 White advances e5 early

Respond to a central break immediately.

Repertoire map / 3

OTHER FIRST MOVES AND POSITIONAL SYSTEMS

Start with HB-13. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

HB-13 Against the London bishop

The bishop on f4 changes the e5 square.

HB-14 Against the Colle structure

A prepared e4 changes the pace of the game.

HB-15 Against the English Opening

Flexible opposing pawns require flexible development.

HB-16 Against the Reti

Expect the opponent to change structures.

HB-17 Against the Bird

Identify which central square the f-pawn supports.

HB-18 Against 1.b3

Check the long diagonal before completing a fianchetto.

Repertoire map / 4

PAWN-BREAK CHOICES AND PARTIAL FORMATIONS

Start with HB-19. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

HB-19 Prepare ...c5 with development

Prepare the break and calculate its consequences.

HB-20 Use ...d5 to challenge e4

A central break is a concrete transformation, not a slogan.

HB-21 White closes with d5

A closed bishop needs a future pawn break.

HB-22 Meet the e5 advance by exchanging

Compare blocking with exchanging before fixing the center.

HB-23 A queenside space grab with a4

If a break is restrained, choose another useful plan.

HB-24 White tries Bh6

Check the knight's square before a queen recapture.